

Module 2.2: Critical Thinking: Sources and their Credibility - Key Terms & Definitions

Credence: The degree of belief.

Expert: A person who, through training, education, or experience, has special knowledge or ability in a subject.

Expertise: An unusual knowledge or ability in a given subject, most often due to specialized **experience** and/or **education**.

- Further indicators: reputation among peers and professional accomplishments.

When should we doubt expert opinion?

- If we have good reasons to believe an expert is biased
- If an expert is being paid or funded by a special interest group or company
- When an expert expresses a strong belief (or disbelief) even though there is no evidence to support their belief
- When the experts stand to gain financially.

Disinterested Party: A person who has no stake in our belief or disbelief in a claim.

Interested Party: A person who stands to gain from our believing his or her claim.